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Introduction to Management, Profa. Simone R. Barakat

# Fieldwork Report

## Organizational Analysis of **MLC Infra**

**Group:** Arthur Malucelli, Matheus Scigliano, Artur Lemos, João Paulo Bicudo, Caio Murari

**Interview:** Ricardo Malucelli, Executive Director (online, May 20, 2026)

# 1. Company Profile

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## General data

- **Name:** MLC Infra
- **HQ:** Curitiba, Paraná
- **Industry:** heavy construction (highways, sanitation, hydroelectric, transmission lines)
- **Workforce:** ~1,200 employees
- **Revenue:** ~BRL 500 million/year
- **Legal type:** privately held S.A.
- **Group:** JMalucelli Group (family-controlled)

## Positioning

- Second-tier national contractor (mid-to-large)
- Strategic focus on **private contracts above BRL 700M**
- Operates indirectly in concessions via 4-firm consortium + financial arm
- Active concessions: **BR-364 (RO)**, **BR-381 (MG)**, 31-32 public schools (PR)
- Competitive narrative: tradition, credibility, decision agility, group solidity

## 2. Operational Process

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A typical infrastructure project at MLC Infra runs through 7 sequential phases over **2 to 5 years**.

### 1 Pre-mobilization

Appoint Contract Manager and key engineering leads; open local branch.

### 2 Setup

Uniforms, occupational health, accommodation, meals, transport, IT.

### 3 Contract & finance

Sign contract, kick-off, ERP setup, cash-flow projection.

### 4 Mobilization

Equipment, workshop, labor, subcontractors, procurement.

### 5 Execution

Topography → earthworks → drainage  
→ paving → signaling.

### 6 Continuous control

Quality tests, monthly measurements, executive reports.

### 7 Closing: contractual handover, financial closure, Definitive Completion Certificate, Technical Acquis at CREA.

## 3. Clients, Suppliers & Stakeholders

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### Clients

- Predominantly **private**
- Strong concentration in **Paraná highway concessionaires**
- Industrial clients (factories, terminals)
- Occasional public contracts

### Suppliers

- **Diesel** (largest expense): Ipiranga, Shell, Unipetro, Petrobras (daily quoting)
- **Cement**: Votorantim partnership
- **Steel**: Gerdau partnership + alternatives
- No single-supplier dependency

### Stakeholders

- Shareholders, clients/contractors
- Employees, suppliers, service providers
- Regulators, unions (employer + labor)
- **Highway users** + host communities
- Broader than typical client-supplier dyad

## 4. Workforce & Human Resources

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### Two distinct populations

- **Corporate** (Curitiba HQ): senior leadership, engineering coordination, commercial, supply chain, legal, HR, safety
- **Field**: each project site led by Contract Manager + production, planning, safety engineers, admin and operators
- Most key positions held by **civil engineers**
- Field crews are mobile; top performers transferred to new projects

**12 years**

average corporate tenure

**90% / 10%**

practice vs. formal study  
(how managers learn at MLC)

### Family-controlled business

MLC Infra belongs to the JMalucelli Group. Multiple Malucelli family members occupy executive positions, including the interviewee.

**Family governance + professionalized operational management**, a recurring pattern in established Brazilian business groups, helps explain the firm's strategic conservatism and emphasis on tradition.

## 5. Administrative Functions (Fayol)

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### Planning

Project-by-project, horizon = contract duration (2-5y).  
Financial expense (~1% per month) embedded in the bid when cash flow goes negative.

### Organizing

Hybrid structure: functional HQ (CEO + Technical, Supply, Commercial Directors) + semi-autonomous project sites under Contract Managers.

### Directing

*"Active management"*: from owner to flag-waving worker, all execute the plan. Formal, disciplined, conservative leadership. Agility as competitive differentiator.

### Controlling

Monthly executive reports per site; corporate monthly reviews. ISO 9001 QMS. Cost overruns trigger immediate corrective action (e.g. diesel price shock).

## 6. Culture & Climate

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Four explicit cultural pillars structure MLC Infra's identity:

### Ethics & Credibility

Transparency in long-term partnerships with clients, suppliers and employees.

### Discipline & Efficiency

Discipline as the vehicle of effectiveness, supporting deadline rigor.

### Quality & Pride

Continuous improvement + valuing company history and team camaraderie.

### Sustainability

Environmental commitment and on-site safety as long-term drivers.

Internal climate is **formal, conservative and disciplined**, consistent with the engineering-dominated workforce. Hierarchical layers are well-defined; decision rituals are formalized through monthly executive reports and ERP-driven dashboards.

## 7. Challenges & Future Outlook

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### Three main challenges

- **Qualified labor scarcity:** number 1 bottleneck, *"disparado o que mais incomoda"*
- **Input price volatility:** diesel R\$5.80 → R\$7.80 = R\$2-3M loss in a single project
- **Adverse external conditions:** climate, environmental licensing, expropriation, network relocation

Self-critical: the firm openly recognizes that it **lags competitors in new technologies and operational procedures**.

### Future outlook

- Securing **large contracts (>BRL 700-800M)** in highways, ferries, ports, airports
- Continued close partnership with new Paraná concessionaires
- Expanding concession portfolio via the 4-construction-firm consortium
- 100% on-time delivery when external factors are excluded; scope changes formalized via contractual amendments



## 8. ESG & Theory-Practice Integration

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### ESG

- Certifications: **ISO 9001 + PBQP-H**
- Practice: ISO 14001 (environment) + ISO 45001 (health & safety) implemented as Integrated Management System
- Social arm: **Joel Malucelli Institute** (culture, sports, education, welfare)
- Priority SDGs: **8** (decent work), **10** (reduced inequalities), **16** (strong institutions)

### Theory connections

- **Weber**, rational-legal bureaucracy (rules, technical qualification, ISO certification)
- **Fayol**, four administrative functions operationalized textbook-style
- **Taylor**, ABC curve for cost prioritization, systematic benchmarking
- **Mayo / Hawthorne**, retention, 12-year tenure, "wearing the shirt"
- **Freeman**, stakeholder theory in the breadth of stakeholder map

## 9. Conclusion

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MLC Infra is a **mature, traditional and disciplined heavy-construction firm** whose competitive position rests on financial solidity, decision-making agility and the institutional credibility of the JMalucelli Group.

### Key takeaways

- Textbook application of Fayol's four functions adapted to a project-based business
- Each project site as a semi-autonomous unit under tight corporate oversight
- Strengths: operational discipline, low turnover, robust stakeholder management
- Weakness: technological adoption (self-recognized)

### Closing thought

Classical management theory remains highly relevant in capital-intensive, project-based industries, where the **rigor of planning, organizing, directing and controlling** continues to determine competitive outcomes.

Thank you to **Ricardo Malucelli** and the MLC Infra team for the openness and the time invested in this interview.